PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY • PAPER 2 OPTION B4

EARLY ELIZABETHAN ENGLAND

1558–1588 • Queen, Government & Religion • Challenges Home & Abroad • Elizabethan Society & Exploration



Plate I: The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I (1588). Commemorating the defeat of the Spanish invasion fleet; Elizabeth rests her hand upon the global sphere, flanked by the English naval triumph. Woburn Abbey Collection.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW • 1558–1588 — **MONARCHY, RELIGION & EMPIRE**

Ascending the throne in November 1558 amidst religious tumult, crippling Crown debt of £300,000, and foreign encirclement by France and Scotland, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth Tudor established a durable Protestant state. Her 1559 Religious Settlement crafted an enduring political compromise between Catholic traditionalism and Calvinist zeal, establishing the English monarch as Supreme Governor of the Church of England while preserving political order across thirty precarious years.

Yet her reign was fiercely tested by domestic rebellion and geopolitical crisis. The flight of Mary, Queen of Scots ignited northern Catholic insurrections, papal excommunication, and deadly assassination conspiracies, while maritime privateering by Francis Drake escalated into outright war with the superpower of Europe—Philip II's Spain. Culminating in the cataclysmic defeat of the 1588 Spanish Armada, this master textbook provides an authoritative 28-page narrative tracing how Elizabeth secured her realm and forged an oceanic Golden Age.

KT 1 Queen, Government & Religion (1558–69) • KT 2 Challenges Home & Abroad (1569–88) • KT 3 Elizabethan Society & Exploration (1558–88)

COURSE SPECIFICATION & DISCIPLINARY DIRECTORY

FULL SYLLABUS ALIGNMENT ACROSS ALL 12 CANONICAL LESSONS (KEY TOPICS 1–3) • OPTION B4

OFFICIAL SPECIFICATION ALIGNMENT

KEY TOPIC 1 QUEEN, GOVERNMENT AND RELIGION, 1558–69

KT 1.1 The Situation on Elizabeth's Accession

Spread 1 • pp. 4–5

Ascending the throne in 1558, Elizabeth governed a deeply stratified **society and government**. *Her rule was shadowed by fierce questions regarding her* **legitimacy, gender, marriage**, *yet she possessed formidable intelligence. Elizabeth immediately confronted dangerous structural challenges at home and abroad: acute Crown* **financial weaknesses, religious divisions**, *and the imminent* **French threat** *from Scotland.*

KT 1.2 The 'Settlement' of Religion

Spread 2 • pp. 6–7

To reconcile a fractured nation, Elizabeth enacted the historic **religious settlement (1559)**, *establishing the middle way via the Act of Supremacy and Act of Uniformity with its Royal Injunctions. The newly reformed* **Church of England** *asserted its central role in society, enforcing national conformity, preaching royal obedience, and conducting village parish administration across England.*

KT 1.3 Challenge to the Religious Settlement

Spread 3 • pp. 8–9

The middle way faced aggressive opposition from two extremes. The activist **Puritan challenge** *demanded the eradication of all popish vestments and crucifixes. Concurrently, a dangerous* **Catholic challenge** *gathered momentum, sustained by traditional Northern nobility, Jesuit missionary infiltration, and external encouragement from the* **Papacy and foreign powers** *like Spain and Catholic France.*

KT 1.4 The Problem of Mary, Queen of Scots

Spread 4 • pp. 10–11

Fleeing Scottish rebellion in 1568, Catholic cousin **Mary, Queen of Scots** *arrived in England, possessing a potent dynastic* **claim to the English throne** *that attracted disaffected nobles. Delicate relations between* **Elizabeth and Mary, 1568–69** *deteriorated into permanent house arrest, as Elizabeth wrestled with the profound danger of executing an anointed monarch.*

KEY TOPIC 2 CHALLENGES TO ELIZABETH AT HOME AND ABROAD, 1569–88

KT 2.1 Plots and Revolts at Home

Spread 5 • pp. 12–13

Northern Catholic grievances erupted in the **Revolt of the Northern Earls, 1569–70**. *Subsequent foreign-backed conspiracies—the* **Ridolfi, Throckmorton and Babington plots**—*sought Elizabeth's assassination, but were systematically dismantled by Sir Francis* **Walsingham and the use of spies**, *directly culminating in the dramatic trial and* **Mary Queen of Scots' execution in 1587**.

KT 2.2 Relations with Spain

Spread 6 • pp. 14–15

Mounting geopolitical friction ignited deep political, religious and commercial **rivalry** *between Tudor England and Philip II's global empire. Protestant-Catholic antagonism intersected with illicit English trade in the Caribbean, where licensed state* **privateering** *and the lucrative plundering* **activities of Drake** *seizing Spanish silver fleets brought the two powers to the brink of open war.*

KT 2.3 Outbreak of War with Spain, 1585–88

Spread 7 • pp. 16–17

Relations collapsed following direct military intervention in the Spanish **Netherlands** *under the 1585 Treaty of Nonsuch and the controversial actions of* **Robert Dudley**, *Earl of Leicester. War became overt in 1587 when Sir Francis* **Drake** *executed the daring naval* **raid on Cadiz**, *destroying vital supplies in the famous 'Singeing the King of Spain's beard'.*

KT 2.4 The Armada

Spread 8 • pp. 18–19

Philip II launched colossal **invasion plans** *in 1588 to transport Parma's veteran army across the Channel. Through tactical blunders and English fire-ships at Gravelines, the key events of the* **Spanish Armada** *resulted in disaster. Decisive reasons for the* **English victory** *included superior gunnery, Drake's nimble galleons, defensive communications, and catastrophic North Sea storms.*

KEY TOPIC 3 ELIZABETHAN SOCIETY IN THE AGE OF EXPLORATION, 1558–88

KT 3.1 Education and Leisure

Spread 9 • pp. 20–21

Humanist ideas drove an expansion of grammar school **education** *for wealthy boys, literacy, and dame schools, while girls remained confined to domestic tuition. Elizabethan leisure reflected social hierarchy, from violent* **sport, pastimes** *like bear-baiting and hawking to the wildly popular secular flowering of purpose-built public* **theatre** *featuring Marlowe and early Shakespeare.*

KT 3.2 The 'Problem' of the Poor

Spread 10 • pp. 22–23

Bad harvests, population growth, rack-renting, and sheep enclosure caused a alarming increase in **poverty and vagabondage**. *Fear of rural disorder transformed traditional moral condemnation into changing legislative* **attitudes and policies**, *distinguishing between the 'deserving' and 'idle' poor, and establishing local poor rates through landmark Elizabethan Poor Laws.*

KT 3.3 Exploration and Voyages of Discovery

Spread 11 • pp. 24–25

Maritime expansion was propelled by revolutionary **new technology on ships and sailing**, *including the astrolabe, triangular lateen sails, and the commercial drive to* **expand trade** *beyond European cloth markets. National prestige surged with* **Drake's circumnavigation of the globe** *(1577–80), reaping immense plunder and establishing England as a formidable oceanic maritime power.*

KT 3.4 Attempted Colonisation of Virginia

Spread 12 • pp. 26–27

Imperial ambitions motivated the **attempted colonisation of Virginia**, *spearheaded by Sir Walter* **Raleigh** *to challenge Spanish hegemony and establish permanent New World bases. Despite intense royal backing, the* **failure of the first settlement** *at Roanoke resulted from poor planning, hostile Indigenous relations, severe supply starvation, and the complete disappearance of the 'Lost Colony'.*

CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONE SPINE & TURNING POINTS

18 DEFINING CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ACROSS ALL 12 CANONICAL LESSONS • OPTION B4

CHRONOLOGICAL HIGHWAY

17 Nov 1558

Accession of Queen Elizabeth I & Appointment of William Cecil

Following the death of Mary I, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth Tudor ascends the throne, inheriting £300,000 in debt; Sir William Cecil is appointed Principal Secretary.

8 May 1559

The Elizabethan Religious Settlement Passed by Parliament

The Act of Supremacy establishes Elizabeth as "Supreme Governor" of the Church of England; the Act of Uniformity imposes the 1559 Book of Common Prayer and 1s recusancy fines.

24 Jun 1559

Royal Injunctions Enforce Uniformity & Church Visitations

Royal Injunctions mandate English liturgy, enforce clerical vestments, ban unauthorized preaching, and initiate nation-wide inspections by royal commissioners.

26 Mar 1566

The Lambeth Vestments Crisis & Archbishop Parker's Advertisements

Archbishop Matthew Parker commands London clergy to wear the surplice; thirty-seven Puritan ministers refuse on grounds of conscience and are stripped of their livings.

16 May 1568

Mary, Queen of Scots Flees into England Across the Solway Firth

Escaping imprisonment at Lochleven following defeat at Langside, Mary Stuart lands at Workington in Cumbria, creating an immediate dynastic crisis for the English Crown.

Oct 1568

The York and Westminster Inquiries Convene over the Casket Letters

Scottish Protestant lords present the mysterious Casket Letters implicating Mary in Lord Darnley's murder; Cecil engineers an inconclusive verdict to detain Mary indefinitely.

Nov 1569

The Revolt of the Northern Earls (The Rising of the North)

The Catholic Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland seize Durham Cathedral, celebrate Catholic Mass, and march south to free Mary Stuart; the rebellion is crushed and 450 rebels executed.

25 Feb 1570

Pope Pius V Issues the Papal Bull Regnans in Excelsis

The Pope excommunicates Elizabeth as a heretic, absolving all Catholic subjects from their oath of allegiance and transforming English Catholics into potential traitors in law.

Mar 1571

The Ridolfi Plot Uncovered by Elizabeth's Intelligence Network

Italian banker Roberto Ridolfi conspires with the Duke of Norfolk and Spain to assassinate Elizabeth; Norfolk is tried for high treason and executed on Tower Hill in 1572.

1572

The Vagabonds Act Introduces Compulsory Parish Poor Rates

Parliament mandates harsh physical punishments (whipping and ear-boring) for idle vagrants while establishing the first statutory compulsory poor relief system administered by JPs.

26 Sep 1580

Francis Drake Completes Global Circumnavigation in the Golden Hind

Drake returns to Plymouth with £400,000 in seized Spanish treasure; Elizabeth defies King Philip II by boarding the Golden Hind at Deptford and knighting Drake in April 1581.

Nov 1583

The Throckmorton Plot Exposed & The Bond of Association Formed

Francis Throckmorton confesses under torture on the rack to a French Catholic invasion plan backed by Spanish money; Council leaders establish the lethal Bond of Association.

1584

Walter Raleigh Granted Royal Patent for North American Colonisation

Elizabeth grants Raleigh a charter to explore and settle unclaimed lands; Arthur Barlowe's expedition scouts Roanoke Island and returns to London praising "Virginia".

20 Aug 1585

The Treaty of Nonsuch Commits English Troops to the Netherlands

Following William of Orange's assassination and the Treaty of Joinville, Elizabeth signs the Treaty of Nonsuch, sending 7,400 soldiers under Leicester, entering direct war with Spain.

Jul 1586

The Babington Plot Intercepted: Walsingham Cracks the Cipher

Sir Francis Walsingham intercepts and deciphers letters hidden in beer barrels between Anthony Babington and Mary Stuart, obtaining Mary's explicit written consent to regicide.

8 Feb 1587

Execution of Mary, Queen of Scots at Fotheringhay Castle

Following parliamentary petitions and Cecil's pressure, Elizabeth signs the death warrant; Mary Stuart is beheaded in the Great Hall, removing the Catholic dynastic figurehead.

19 Apr 1587

Drake's Raid on Cadiz ("Singeing the King of Spain's Beard")

Sir Francis Drake leads an audacity-fueled preemptive naval assault on Cadiz harbour, destroying over thirty Spanish warships and burning thousands of seasoned oak barrel staves.

8 Aug 1588

The Battle of Gravelines & The Dispersal of the Spanish Armada

English fireships break the Armada crescent off Calais; race-built galleons batter Spanish hulls at close range; westerly gale winds drive the surviving invasion fleet into the North Sea.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did an inexperienced queen secure an impoverished and divided England amidst acute foreign encirclement in 1558?

[1.1] *1558*

Hatfield Oak to the Tower: Inheriting Bankruptcy and Cecil's Partnership

> ***"Why did inherited debt and foreign loans create an immediate crisis for the new Queen?"***

On a cold November morning in 1558, twenty-five-year-old **Elizabeth Tudor** received word beneath an oak tree at Hatfield House that her half-sister Mary was dead and she was now Queen of England. Elizabeth was exceptionally intelligent, confident, and highly educated, speaking fluent Latin, French, and Italian. Having narrowly survived imprisonment in the Tower of London during Mary's reign, she had developed a sharp political instinct and a cautious nature. Yet the realm she inherited was on the brink of financial disaster.

England was burdened by an astronomical **£300,000 Crown debt**, largely run up fighting costly wars in France. The Crown's ordinary annual income was barely **£286,000**, forcing the government to borrow heavily from moneylenders on the **Antwerp Exchange** at ruinous interest rates of **14 per cent**. To rescue royal finances, Elizabeth immediately appointed her most trusted advisor, **Sir William Cecil**, as Principal Secretary, beginning a campaign to slash household expenses, sell royal lands, and bring stability to the treasury.

[1.2] *1558*

The Royal Court & Privy Council: Patronage, Factional Flattery and the 19-Man Council

> ***"How did Elizabeth use patronage and factional competition to secure political control?"***

Tudor monarchical governance was rooted in the concept of **Divine Right**, but the Crown possessed no standing army or professional police force. Sovereign power was directed by the monarch and a small, elite **Privy Council** of nineteen trusted advisors who met daily to manage state finance, national defence, and foreign policy.

Elizabeth secured political stability by balancing rival court factions against one another. She distributed **royal patronage and monopolies**—exclusive commercial licences and profitable offices—to secure noble loyalty without surrendering monarchical authority, preventing ambitious aristocrats from uniting in rebellion.

[1.3] *1558*

Challenges of Gender & Marriage: Female Monarchical Rule, Legitimacy and Knox's Opposition

> ***"Why did challenges to Elizabeth's gender and legitimacy threaten domestic stability?"***

Elizabethan government was centred entirely around the monarch, who claimed to rule by **Divine Right**—the belief that kings and queens were appointed directly by God. The **Court** was made up of noblemen, advisers, and servants who travelled with the Queen from palace to palace. The Court was the stage where Elizabeth displayed her magnificent wealth and authority, and where ambitious courtiers competed for royal favour.

The real engine of national government was the **Privy Council**, a select group of around 19 senior noblemen and statesmen meeting almost daily to manage defense, tax collection, and foreign affairs. Elizabeth controlled her powerful nobles through **patronage**—distributing titles, land leases, and lucrative trade monopolies. By balancing rival factions at court, especially between the cautious William Cecil and her dashing favourite, Lord Robert Dudley, Elizabeth ensured that no single noble clique could dominate her decisions.

[1.4] 1559

Whitehall to the Shires: Reluctant Parliaments and Unpaid Country JPs

"Why was Elizabeth entirely dependent on unpaid local gentry to enforce royal authority?"

Elizabeth possessed great power, but she was not an absolute ruler. The Crown had no standing army and no national police force, and Elizabeth could not pass new laws or raise taxes without the consent of **Parliament**. Parliament was made up of the House of Lords (nobles and bishops) and the House of Commons (wealthy elected landowners and town leaders). Elizabeth viewed Parliament as a necessary nuisance, calling MPs only nine times during her 45-year reign, primarily to grant **extraordinary taxation** (subsidies) during national emergencies or wars.

Across the English counties, the Crown relied entirely on unpaid local gentlemen to carry out royal orders. Each county was headed by a **Lord Lieutenant**, a great nobleman appointed by the Queen to govern the region and train the local militia for defence. Beneath them, **Justices of the Peace (JPs)** drawn from the county gentry maintained daily law and order, sat as judges in quarterly court sessions, repaired roads, and collected taxes.

[1.5] 1558–1560

The Catholic Pincer: The Surrender of Calais and French Troops on the Tweed

"Why did the Auld Alliance and the loss of Calais make England vulnerable to foreign invasion?"

Beyond England's borders, Elizabeth faced an immediate military crisis from the Catholic alliance between France and Scotland. In January 1558, French forces had captured **Calais**, England's last continental possession, humiliating the nation and leaving the southern coast vulnerable to cross-Channel invasion. The loss of continental Calais confirmed England's military isolation.

To the north, Mary of Guise governed Scotland with a garrison of French troops, creating a dangerous Catholic pincer around England. Mary Stuart, Queen of Scots, quartered the English royal coat of arms with the French fleur-de-lis, openly claiming the English throne. Financially exhausted, Elizabeth concluded the **Treaty of Cateau-Cambrésis (1559)**, acknowledging the loss of Calais to avoid ruinous war.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Executive Institutionalisation • Factional Patronage and Cecil's Bureaucratic Partnership**

Elizabeth overcame the structural weakness of inherited bankruptcy and patriarchal prejudice by balancing rival court factions and binding the aristocracy through royal patronage.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

To what extent was the 1559 Religious Settlement an enduring theological compromise designed to prevent civil war?

[2.1] *1558–1559*

A Fractured Realm: Marian Burnings, Geneva Exiles and the Search for Peace

> ***"Why did England's geographic and political divisions make a religious settlement essential?"***

When Elizabeth came to the throne, England was deeply scarred by thirty years of religious turmoil. Henry VIII had broken with Rome in the 1530s, Edward VI had introduced strict Protestantism, and Mary I had brutally restored Roman Catholicism, burning nearly 300 Protestants at the stake. This rapid pendulum swing left the nation bitterly divided and on edge.

Geography deepened this religious rift. In the remote North and West, conservative landowners and peasants remained fiercely loyal to the traditional Roman Catholic faith, the Latin Mass, and church decorations. In contrast, London, the South-East, and trading ports had embraced the Protestant Reformation, demanding an English Bible and a clean break from the Pope. Elizabeth's supreme challenge was to craft a religious settlement that would bring peace and prevent a devastating civil war.

[2.2] *1559*

The Crown Restored: The Act of Supremacy and the Title of Supreme Governor

> ***"Why did Elizabeth choose the title 'Supreme Governor' instead of 'Supreme Head'?"***

In May 1559, Elizabeth steered the **Act of Supremacy** through Parliament, formally establishing England's independence from the Pope. In a brilliant political compromise, Elizabeth chose the title **"Supreme Governor"** of the Church of England, rather than "Supreme Head" as her father Henry VIII had used.

This subtle difference was crucial. It comforted Catholics, who believed that only Jesus Christ or the Pope could be the earthly head of the Church, and it reassured Protestants who felt that a woman could not hold spiritual headship over holy matters. The Act required all clergy and royal officials to take an **Oath of Supremacy** swearing loyalty to Elizabeth. While all but one Catholic bishop refused and lost their positions, the overwhelming majority of ordinary parish priests—around 8,000 out of 9,000—took the oath and kept their livings.

[2.3] *1559*

The Altar of Compromise: The Act of Uniformity, Liturgy and One-Shilling Recusancy

> ***"How did the Act of Uniformity attempt to compromise between Catholic and Protestant worship?"***

Passed alongside Supremacy, the **Act of Uniformity** dictated the exact appearance of every church and established a single, uniform order of service across the entire country. Every parish church was legally required to use the new 1559 **Book of Common Prayer** in English, ending the Latin Catholic Mass.

To keep both sides from rebelling, the Prayer Book contained clever theological compromises. During Communion, the wording for receiving the bread and wine was deliberately ambiguous: Protestants could view it as a spiritual commemoration of Christ's sacrifice, while traditional Catholics could still believe in the miracle of transubstantiation. At the same time, churches were permitted to keep moderate decorations, candles, and priests were required to wear traditional white surplices, reassuring conservative worshippers that their local church felt familiar.

[2.4] *1559*

The Royal Injunctions: Crucifix Bans, Clerical Surplices and Church Visitations

> *"How did the Royal Injunctions establish central royal control over local parish life?"*

In the summer of 1559, William Cecil issued 57 **Royal Injunctions** to ensure every parish enforced the new laws. Royal commissioners visited every diocese to inspect churches, administer the Oath of Supremacy, and ensure that every church bought an English Bible. Images, pilgrimages, and false miracles were strictly forbidden, and clergy required special licences to preach to stop religious rabble-rousing.

Church attendance on Sundays and holy days was made strictly compulsory. Anyone who refused to attend church was labelled a **recusant** and fined **one shilling**—roughly a week's pay for a common labourer. However, Elizabeth famously declared that she had no desire to "make windows into men's souls." During the first decade of her reign, recusancy fines were rarely collected with harshness, allowing quiet Catholic families to conform outwardly without fear of persecution.

[2.5] *1559–1560s*

The Pulpit of the Realm: Church Courts, Royal Homilies and Community Feasts

> *"How effectively did royal visitations and Church courts enforce conformity across England?"*

The Elizabethan regime dispatched royal commissioners on nationwide **Visitations in 1559** to inspect parish churches and administer the Oath of Supremacy. Approximately 400 clergy members resigned or were deprived of their livings rather than conform, but the vast majority of ordinary priests took the oath, securing national religious continuity.

The Church also maintained social discipline through local **church courts**. These courts settled community disputes, granted marriage licences, inspected wills, and punished moral offences such as drunkenness, slander, and adultery. Moral offences supervised by courts ensured that parish churches remained effective instruments of royal order and community cohesion.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **The Via Media Compromise • Deliberate Doctrinal Ambiguity and Monarchical Supremacy**

By adopting the title Supreme Governor and blending Protestant liturgy with traditional ceremonial vestments, Elizabeth established state control while averting violent religious civil strife.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did ideological opposition from Puritan zealots and Catholic traditionalists threaten Elizabeth's middle way in the 1560s?

[3.1] *1559–1563*

The Puritan Challenge: Beliefs, Demands and the Crucifix Controversy

> ***"Why did Puritan religious demands pose a direct challenge to Elizabeth's royal authority?"***

Despite Elizabeth's hopes for a peaceful compromise, her Religious Settlement immediately came under fire from radical Protestants known as **Puritans**. Influenced by John Calvin's strict Reformation in Geneva, Puritans believed the Elizabethan Church was half-reformed and still contaminated by Catholic superstition. They demanded that the Church be completely "purified" of everything not explicitly commanded in the Bible.

Puritans wanted all Catholic rituals swept away. They demanded the abolition of bishops, arguing that church congregations should be governed democratically by elected elders (presbyteries). They wanted church walls whitewashed, stained glass smashed, organs silenced, and altars replaced with simple wooden tables. Puritans also led a strict moral crusade against popular leisure, demanding the banning of theatres, gambling, cock-fighting, and Sunday drinking.

[3.2] *1566*

The Vestments Controversy: Archbishop Parker, the Surplice Dispute and Puritan Defiance

> ***"Why did the dispute over clergy vestments become a major test of Elizabeth's control?"***

Puritan opposition quickly exploded into open defiance over church symbols and dress. During the **Crucifix Controversy**, Elizabeth demanded that a silver crucifix remain in the Royal Chapel and ordered crosses in every parish church to soothe Catholic worshippers. Puritan bishops protested vigorously, threatening to resign en masse. Lacking enough educated Protestant clergymen to replace them, Elizabeth was forced to back down, allowing crucifixes to be removed from local churches.

In 1566, the conflict flared again in the **Vestment Controversy**. Elizabeth insisted that priests wear the traditional white linen surplice during services, but radical Puritans condemned them as "popish rags." In response, Archbishop Matthew Parker issued the **Book of Advertisements**, ordering all clergy to conform. When 110 London priests were summoned to Lambeth Palace to model the required vestments, **37 refused** and were immediately stripped of their jobs, proving that Elizabeth would not allow Puritan defiance to weaken royal authority.

[3.3] *1559–1568*

The Catholic Stronghold: Northern Magnates, Manor Altars and Church Papists

> ***"Why was Elizabeth able to tolerate moderate Catholic non-conformity during the early 1560s?"***

Domestic Catholic opposition was widespread but initially cautious. In the conservative northern counties and Lancashire, powerful magnates such as the Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland remained loyal to the traditional Catholic Latin mass. Many Catholic families maintained secret chapels in their country manor houses, hiding outlawed Catholic priests in concealed priests' holes.

For the first decade of her reign, Elizabeth adopted a pragmatic policy of political conciliation. Moderate Catholics who attended compulsory parish services became known as **Church Papists**, and lax local JPs in the north frequently overlooked recusancy. Elizabeth avoided creating martyrs who might provoke open Catholic rebellion, famously resolving that she had "no desire to make windows into men's souls" as long as they remained outwardly loyal subjects.

[3.4] *1562–1568*

The Counter-Reformation Shadow: Alba's Tercios, Douai Seminaries and the Jesuit Mission

> *"Why did the arrival of Alba's Spanish army in the Netherlands alarm the English Privy Council?"*

Following the failed Revolt of the Northern Earls, the Catholic threat took a terrifying international turn. In February 1570, **Pope Pius V** issued the historic papal bull ***Regnans in Excelsis***, formally excommunicating Elizabeth and condemning her as a heretic and a usurper.

The papal bull commanded all faithful Roman Catholics to withdraw their loyalty from Elizabeth, declaring that any English Catholic who continued to obey her laws would also face excommunication. This fatal decree put English Catholics in an impossible position: they could no longer be both loyal English patriots and faithful Roman Catholics. To Elizabeth's government, Catholic worship was no longer treated as religious non-conformity—it was now viewed as outright treason against the Crown.

[3.5] *1568–1569*

The Genoese Loan: Spanish Silver, Trade Embargoes and the Edge of War

> *"How did the seizure of the Genoese Loan push England and Spain closer to open conflict?"*

Abroad, the Catholic **Counter-Reformation** gathered fierce momentum as the Papacy urged Europe's Catholic superpowers to extinguish Protestantism. Fortunately for Elizabeth, France was paralyzed from 1562 by its own bloody French Wars of Religion, preventing French Catholic forces from mounting an invasion across the Channel.

However, a deadly storm was brewing in the Spanish Netherlands, directly across the Channel. When Dutch Protestants rebelled against Spanish rule, King Philip II dispatched the ruthless **Duke of Alba** with an army of 10,000 battle-hardened Spanish troops in 1567 to crush the revolt. Alba established the notorious "Council of Blood," executing thousands of Protestant rebels. With a massive Spanish invasion force stationed just a short sail from the English coast, Elizabeth faced the terrifying prospect of a foreign Catholic invasion.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Confessional Polarisation • The Radicalisation of Conscience and Foreign Geopolitical Pressure**

The Elizabethan settlement was squeezed between uncompromising Calvinists demanding total reformation and traditionalists sustained by continental Catholic armies and Douai seminaries.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did the arrival of Mary, Queen of Scots in 1568 transform Elizabeth's dynastic security into a permanent national crisis?

[4.1] *1560–1565*

Two Anointed Queens: The Scottish Succession, Bloodline Rivalry and the French Pincer

> *"Why did Mary Stuart's royal ancestry and marriage choices threaten Elizabeth's security?"*

The greatest dynastic threat to Elizabeth arrived in the form of her charismatic cousin, **Mary Stuart**, Queen of Scots. Born in 1542, Mary was the granddaughter of Henry VIII's elder sister, **Margaret Tudor**, giving her an undisputed royal lineage. To Roman Catholics who rejected Henry VIII's marriage to Anne Boleyn, Elizabeth was illegitimate, making Mary the rightful, legitimate Queen of England and a natural Catholic figurehead.

Raised in France and widowed following the death of King Francis II, Mary returned to Edinburgh in 1561 to rule a Scotland dominated by Protestant lords. In 1565, Mary dramatically strengthened her dynastic claim by marrying her English Catholic cousin, **Henry Stuart, Lord Darnley**, who was also descended from Margaret Tudor. This marriage united the two strongest alternative claims to the English throne, creating an alarming threat on Elizabeth's northern border.

[4.2] *1567*

Kirk o' Field: Gunpowder Treason, Bothwell's Ambition and Darnley's Murder

> *"Why did Darnley's murder and Mary's marriage to Bothwell ruin her authority in Scotland?"*

In 1565, Mary made a fateful political blunder by marrying her handsome, ambitious cousin, **Lord Darnley**, securing the royal line with the birth of a son, Prince James. However, Darnley quickly proved to be violent, drunken, and intensely jealous. In March 1566, Darnley and a group of Protestant nobles burst into Mary's private chambers at Holyrood Palace and brutally stabbed her Italian secretary, David Rizzio, fifty-six times in front of the pregnant Queen.

The marriage was shattered beyond repair. In February 1567, Darnley's residence at Kirk o' Field was blown apart by barrels of gunpowder, and Darnley's body was found strangled in the orchard. Outrage swept Scotland when Mary married the chief suspect in the murder, the **Earl of Bothwell**, just three months later. Convinced that Mary was complicit in her husband's murder, the Scottish Protestant nobility rose in furious armed rebellion.

[4.3] *1567–1568*

Lochleven to the Solway: Abdication, Island Dungeon and Mary's Desperate Flight

> *"Why did Mary's unexpected arrival in England present Elizabeth with an impossible dilemma?"*

Defeated by rebel lords at Carberry Hill, Mary was imprisoned in the isolated island fortress of **Lochleven Castle**. Under intense intimidation, she was forced on 24 July 1567 to sign deeds of **abdication** in favour of her one-year-old infant son, who was crowned King **James VI**, with her Protestant half-brother, the Earl of Moray, ruling as regent.

In May 1568, Mary pulled off a daring escape from the castle, gathered a small force of loyal Catholic supporters, but was decisively routed at the Battle of Langside. Desperate and ignoring the warnings of her closest advisors, Mary climbed into a small fishing boat and sailed across the Solway Firth, landing at **Workington in Cumberland** on 16 May 1568. Mary believed her "sister Queen" Elizabeth would welcome her with open arms and provide an army to reconquer Scotland.

[4.4] *1568–1569*

The York Inquiry: The Mysterious Casket Letters and Cecil's Stalemate

> ***"Why did Elizabeth choose an inconclusive verdict rather than declaring Mary guilty or innocent?"***

Following Mary's arrival in England, Elizabeth ordered an official judicial conference at **York and Westminster (1568–69)** to investigate the murder of Lord Darnley. Scottish Protestant regents produced the disputed **Casket Letters**—eight French casket love letters and sonnets allegedly written by Mary to Bothwell, proving her complicity in the murder.

Mary's defence insisted the letters were complete Protestant forgeries, but Mary was refused direct cross-examination before the commissioners. Refusing to validate the rebellion of Scottish subjects against an anointed queen, Elizabeth declared an inconclusive "not proven" verdict: this lack of a guilty verdict justified Mary's continued detention without formally executing her.

[4.5] *1569*

The Gilded Cage: Bolton Castle, Northern Vigilance and the Threat to Whitehall

> ***"Why did Mary Stuart's presence in England inevitably lead to armed Catholic rebellion?"***

Following the inquiry, Mary was placed under honourable confinement in remote aristocratic estates, principally under the custody of **George Talbot, Earl of Shrewsbury**, at Tutbury Castle and Sheffield Manor. While guarded securely, Mary's presence in England acted as an immediate magnet for northern Catholic discontent.

In 1569, disaffected Catholic nobles devised the **Duke of Norfolk court marriage plot**, scheming to marry England's premier peer to Mary and restore her to the Scottish throne. When Elizabeth discovered and forbade the marriage, the crisis triggered the armed Revolt of the Northern Earls.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Dynastic Entrapment • The Legitimate Catholic Alternative and Sovereign Impasse**

As Henry VII's great-granddaughter and an anointed Catholic sovereign, Mary's presence on English soil created an inescapable focal point for Catholic rebellion and foreign invasion.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did escalating assassination conspiracies compel Elizabeth to take the unprecedented step of executing an anointed monarch?

[5.1] *1569–1570*

The Northern Fire: Catholic Earls, Durham Cathedral and Tudor Vengeance

> ***"Why did the Northern Earls fail to overthrow Elizabeth despite capturing Durham Cathedral?"***

In November 1569, Catholic discontent erupted into open armed rebellion in northern England. The revolt was led by two powerful northern Catholic magnates: **Charles Neville, Earl of Westmorland**, and **Thomas Percy, Earl of Northumberland**. The earls were furious at being excluded from Elizabeth's court by William Cecil, angry at the loss of copper mining rights on their lands, and determined to restore traditional Roman Catholicism to England.

The rebels plotted to marry **Thomas Howard, Duke of Norfolk** (England's senior nobleman) to Mary, Queen of Scots, and depose Elizabeth. The earls marched on Durham with 4,600 men, captured Durham Cathedral, destroyed the English Communion table, and triumphantly held Latin Catholic Mass. However, Spanish troops promised by Philip II never arrived, and the revolt collapsed when the Earl of Sussex marched north with an army of 14,000 royal troops. Elizabeth took ruthless revenge, executing **over 450 rebel peasants** to terrorize the north into obedience.

[5.2] *1570–1572*

Regnans in Excelsis & The Ridolfi Conspiracy: Intercepted Ciphers and Norfolk's Axe

> ***"How did the 1570 Papal Bull transform the legal and political danger facing English Catholics?"***

In 1570, Pope Pius V issued the historic papal bull **Regnans in Excelsis**, excommunicating Queen Elizabeth and releasing English Catholics from their allegiance. In 1571, an Italian banker living in London, **Roberto Ridolfi**, orchestrated a conspiracy with international backing from Rome and King Philip II of Spain. Operating as an Italian banker conspiracy courier, Ridolfi travelled between Rome, Madrid, and Brussels to coordinate a foreign invasion.

The plot called for the Duke of Alba to land 10,000 Spanish troops at Harwich, march on London, assassinate Elizabeth, and place Mary on the throne married to the Duke of Norfolk. However, William Cecil's intelligence agents intercepted Ridolfi's messengers and decrypted their ciphers. Norfolk was arrested, tried for high treason, and **executed on Tower Hill in June 1572**.

[5.3] *1583–1584*

The Jesuit Shadow & Throckmorton's Confession: The Rack and the Bond of Association

> ***"Why did the discovery of the Throckmorton Plot lead to harsher anti-Catholic measures?"***

By the early 1580s, the Catholic threat was fueled by seminary priests and Jesuit missionaries arriving secretly from Europe. In 1583, a young English Catholic nobleman named **Francis Throckmorton** became the central courier for a dangerous new international conspiracy. The plan was for the French **Duke of Guise** (Mary's cousin) to land an invasion force in Sussex, financed by King Philip II and the Pope, to assassinate Elizabeth and liberate Mary.

The conspiracy was uncovered by **Sir Francis Walsingham**, Elizabeth's brilliant and ruthless Spymaster. Walsingham placed Throckmorton's London house under surveillance, arrested him, and put him on the rack until he confessed the entire plot. Throckmorton was executed at Tyburn. The terrifying discovery that Mary was actively collaborating with foreign Catholic invaders led Cecil and Walsingham to draft the **Bond of Association (1584)**: a nationwide pledge that anyone plotting against Elizabeth would be put to death, along with any royal claimant who stood to benefit from it.

[5.4] *1586*

The Beer Barrel Cryptograms: Walsingham's Trap and Babington's Fatal Sign-Off

> ***"How did Walsingham use espionage and deciphered correspondence to trap Mary Stuart?"***

In 1586, Catholic conspirators made their final attempt to assassinate Elizabeth and place Mary on the throne. Led by **Anthony Babington**, a wealthy young Catholic gentleman, the plot was backed by Philip II and the Pope, who promised Spanish troops the moment Elizabeth was dead. Babington established contact with Mary, who was now held in tight confinement at Chartley Manor in Staffordshire under the strict Puritan warden Sir Amias Paulet.

Babington used an undercover Catholic priest, Gilbert Gifford, to smuggle encrypted messages inside **waterproof beer barrels** delivered to Mary's kitchen. Unbeknownst to Babington, Gifford was a double agent working for Walsingham. Every letter was intercepted, copied, and decoded by Walsingham's expert cryptanalyst, **Thomas Phelippes**. On 17 July 1586, Mary sent the fatal reply approving Elizabeth's assassination ("four stout men"). Walsingham had the irrefutable proof he needed. Babington and his fellow conspirators were rounded up and brutally hanged, drawn, and quartered at St Giles' Fields.

[5.5] *1587*

The Great Hall at Fotheringhay: The Regicide Dilemma and Mary's Red Execution

> ***"Why was Elizabeth so reluctant to execute Mary Queen of Scots despite proven treason?"***

In October 1586, Mary was brought to trial at **Fotheringhay Castle** in Northamptonshire. Charged under the 1585 Act for the Queen's Safety, she defended herself with great dignity, arguing that as an anointed foreign queen, no English court had the legal authority to try her. Nonetheless, confronted with the intercepted Babington letters, the 36 commissioners found her guilty of high treason and sentenced her to death.

Elizabeth agonized for four months over signing the death warrant. She feared the sin of executing a God-anointed monarch and dreaded the retaliation of Spain, France, and Mary's son, King James VI. Finally, on 1 February 1587, Elizabeth signed the warrant, but ordered her secretary William Davison not to dispatch it without further command. The Privy Council acted secretly behind her back, sending the warrant to Fotheringhay. On **8 February 1587**, Mary was beheaded before 300 witnesses in the Great Hall. Her execution removed the Catholic figurehead for English rebellion, but it gave King Philip II the final moral and religious pretext he needed to launch the Spanish Armada.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Preemptive Surveillance • Cryptanalysis, Agent Provocateurs, and State Security Law**

Faced with papal excommunication and systematic assassination plots, Walsingham's intelligence apparatus weaponised intercepted ciphers to force the execution of Mary Stuart.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did maritime raiding and covert proxy intervention escalate an undeclared cold war into direct military conflict with Spain?

[6.1] *1570–1577*

The Spanish Superpower: Philip II's Empire, the Dutch Revolt and English Sympathy

> ***"Why did Spanish control of the Netherlands threaten English trade and security?"***

For the first decade of Elizabeth's reign, England and Spain maintained a fragile peace. King Philip II of Spain, who had been married to Elizabeth's sister Mary I, initially viewed England as a vital counterweight against Spanish rival France. However, religious ideology soon poisoned relations. As the most powerful monarch in Europe, ruling Spain, parts of Italy, and the New World, Philip saw himself as the divine champion of Roman Catholicism, sworn to eradicate Protestant heresy.

The papal bull of 1570 made open conflict between the two nations an ideological crusade. While Philip secretly financed Catholic plots to overthrow Elizabeth, the Queen allowed English volunteers to fight for Dutch Protestant rebels and opened English ports to Protestant privateers known as the **Sea Beggars**, who preyed on Spanish supply shipping. Though both monarchs avoided an open declaration of war, an undeclared proxy war was escalating across Europe.

[6.2] *1570–1579*

The Silver Route: John Hawkins, Caribbean Privateering and the Cacafuego Loot

> ***"Why did English privateering in the Caribbean inflame diplomatic tensions with Spain?"***

Beyond religion, commercial rivalry in the Atlantic drove England and Spain into bitter conflict. Philip claimed a total monopoly over all trade with Spain's wealthy colonies in the Americas, strictly forbidding foreign merchants from trading without a royal Spanish licence. English merchants, shut out of traditional European cloth markets, saw the New World as a lucrative opportunity for immense wealth.

In the 1560s, Plymouth merchant **Sir John Hawkins** pioneered the English transatlantic slave trade, capturing enslaved people in West Africa and selling them illegally to Spanish colonists in the Caribbean. In 1568, a Spanish fleet attacked Hawkins and his young cousin **Francis Drake** at San Juan de Ulúa in Mexico, sinking three English ships. Drake returned to England swearing lifelong vengeance against Spain and launched a decade of relentless privateering against Spanish treasure fleets.

[6.3] *1577–1580*

The Golden Hind: Drake's Oceanic Voyage, Pacific Plunder and the Plymouth Return

> ***"Why did Drake's circumnavigation represent a direct challenge to the Spanish Empire?"***

Francis Drake became the scourge of the Spanish Empire. In 1572, he captured the Spanish port of **Nombre de Dios** in Panama, intercepting a mule train laden with silver from the mines of Potosí. In December 1577, Drake set out on his historic three-year voyage around the world aboard the *Pelican* (renamed the *Golden Hind*), with Elizabeth secretly financing the venture and granting him permission to raid Spanish territories in the Pacific.

Drake plundered the undefended coasts of Chile and Peru, capturing the great treasure galleon *Cacafuego* with its cargo of 26 tons of silver and thousands of gold coins. When Drake returned to Plymouth in September 1580, his cargo was worth an astonishing **£140,000**, easily covering the Crown's entire foreign debt. In April 1581, Elizabeth openly defied Philip by boarding the *Golden Hind* at Deptford and **knighting Drake** on his own deck—a public insult that infuriated the Spanish King and proved England was ready to challenge Spanish naval mastery.

[6.4] *1580–1581*

The Deptford Knighting: Elizabeth's Defiance, Philip's Outrage and the £10,000 Reward

> *"How did events in Europe between 1580 and 1584 increase the threat of a Spanish invasion?"*

The Netherlands was the flashpoint that pushed England and Spain to war. In 1576, unpaid Spanish troops mutinied and brutally sacked the commercial city of Antwerp—an atrocity known as the "**Spanish Fury**" that left 7,000 citizens dead. In response, all seventeen Dutch provinces united in the **Pacification of Ghent**, demanding the expulsion of all Spanish troops and religious freedom.

However, Philip dispatched his greatest military commander, the **Duke of Parma**, who systematically reconquered the southern Catholic provinces through brilliant diplomacy and siege warfare. In July 1584, the Dutch Protestant leader, **William the Silent (Prince of Orange)**, was assassinated by a Catholic fanatic. Without William's leadership, the Dutch Protestant rebellion was on the verge of total collapse, leaving Elizabeth facing the nightmare of a victorious Spanish army stationed right on the Channel coast.

[6.5] *1584–1585*

The Alliance Hardens: The French Catholic League, Joinville and the Treaty of Nonsuch

> *"Why did the Treaty of Nonsuch mark the point of no return for war between England and Spain?"*

In December 1584, the European balance of power shifted decisively against England. King Philip II signed the secret **Treaty of Joinville** with the powerful French Catholic League, led by the Duke of Guise. The treaty pledged that France and Spain would unite to crush European Protestantism and prevent the Protestant heir, Henry of Navarre, from taking the French throne.

The Treaty of Joinville removed the historic rivalry between France and Spain that had kept England safe for thirty years. For the first time, Philip II had a free hand to attack England without fear of French intervention. Stripped of diplomatic options and facing Spanish domination of the Netherlands, Elizabeth was forced to abandon her policy of cautious neutrality and intervene directly with military force.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Asymmetric Maritime Aggression • State-Sanctioned Piracy and Dutch Strategic Buffer Defense**

By backing privateers who raided Spanish treasure routes and knighting Francis Drake in public defiance of Philip II, Elizabeth provoked open war to defend England's geopolitical frontiers.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did direct English military intervention in the Low Countries force Philip II to launch the "Enterprise of England"?

[7.1] *1585–1586*

The Treaty of Nonsuch: Leicester's Expedition and the Defense of Flushing

> ***"Why did Dudley's campaign in the Netherlands struggle to achieve decisive military success?"***

With Dutch Protestant independence collapsing, Elizabeth finally made the fateful decision to intervene with open military force. In August 1585, she signed the **Treaty of Nonsuch** with the Dutch Protestant rebels, bringing England into direct, formal war against the Spanish Empire.

Under the treaty, Elizabeth agreed to pay for an army of **7,400 English soldiers** led by her favourite courtier, **Robert Dudley, Earl of Leicester**. In return, the Dutch handed over two vital deep-water ports—**Brill and Flushing**—known as the **"Cautionary Towns,"** which English garrisons occupied as financial security for the costs of the war. Philip II regarded the Treaty of Nonsuch as an open declaration of war, and began drafting plans for a full-scale naval invasion of England.

[7.2] *1586–1587*

Disaster in the Low Countries: Zutphen, Desertions and Leicester's Resignation

> ***"How did English betrayals and command disputes damage relations with the Dutch rebels?"***

The English military campaign in the Netherlands proved to be an expensive failure. Elizabeth was reluctant to commit fully, underfunding Leicester's troops and hoping to negotiate peace with Spain. English soldiers lacked food, proper shoes, and wages, leading to low morale and high desertion rates. To make matters worse, Leicester enraged Elizabeth by accepting the title of **"Governor-General of the United Provinces"**, implying that England wanted to usurp Dutch sovereignty.

The campaign was crippled by devastating betrayals. In January 1587, two English Catholic officers appointed by Leicester, **Sir William Stanley** and **Rowland York**, defected to the Spanish side, handing over the fortified town of Deventer and the fort at Zutphen to the Duke of Parma. This catastrophic betrayal shattered Dutch trust in English leadership. Frustrated and disgraced, Leicester resigned his command and returned to England in December 1587, having achieved little more than preventing Parma from capturing the deep-water ports of Zeeland.

[7.3] *1587*

Singeing the King of Spain's Beard: Drake's Daring Raid on Cadiz Harbour

> ***"How did Drake's tactical boldness at Cadiz disrupt the Spanish invasion timetable?"***

By early 1587, Philip II's naval preparations at the Atlantic port of Cadiz were nearing completion. In April, Elizabeth dispatched Francis Drake with a fleet of 24 ships to disrupt Spanish assembly. Defying cautious orders, Drake audaciously sailed his flagship, the *Elizabeth Bonaventure*, directly into Cadiz harbour under the guns of Spanish fortresses.

Over three days, Drake burned and sank **over thirty Spanish ships**, plundered massive supplies, and destroyed tons of seasoned wooden barrel staves needed for food and water storage. Drake boasted that he had **"singed the King of Spain's beard."** The raid delayed the Spanish Armada by more than a year and forced the Spanish to construct fresh, unseasoned water barrels, causing water contamination and disease that devastated the Armada during its voyage.

[7.4] *1587–1588*

The Logistical Shock: Seasoned Barrel Hoops, Scorched Fleets and Spanish Delay

> ***"Why were logistical damage and command changes fatal to the Spanish invasion plan?"***

Drake's daring raid on Cadiz inflicted devastating logistical damage on Spanish war planning. He destroyed thirty warships and destroyed fleet provisions and supplies, including tons of dried food and water barrels. Drake also captured the **San Felipe**, a massive Portuguese treasure ship laden with spices and silks worth £114,000.

Drake burned thousands of seasoned wooden barrel staves, forcing Spain to construct hurried casks from unseasoned green wood. When Spain's legendary naval commander, the Marquis of Santa Cruz, died in 1588, Philip appointed the inexperienced Duke of Medina Sidonia to lead the fleet. When the Armada finally sailed, rotting food and leaking water casks crippled crew morale before a single shot was fired.

[7.5] *1588*

The Enterprise of England: Medina Sidonia Assembles the Great Fleet at Lisbon

> ***"What strategic flaws made Philip II's plan to link the fleet with Parma extremely risky?"***

In May 1588, Philip II's grand Armada of **130 ships and 30,000 men departed from Lisbon** on the "Enterprise of England". Philip's strategy required Medina Sidonia to sail up the English Channel, anchor off Flanders, and ferry the Duke of Parma's 27,000 veteran infantry across in flat-bottomed barges.

However, the invasion plan was compromised by fatal geographic and communication obstacles: Parma lacked a deep-water harbor in the Dutch shallows to shelter his barges from Dutch gunboats, while maritime communication between Medina Sidonia at sea and Parma on land required an unreliable 48-hour message relay by small boat, making synchronization impossible.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Logistical Disruption • Drake's Preemptive Strike and the Fragility of Oceanic Staging**

Although Leicester's expedition in the Netherlands floundered, Drake's daring 1587 raid on Cadiz destroyed critical shipping and barrel staves, buying England sixteen vital months to prepare.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Was the defeat of the Spanish Armada primarily the result of superior English naval technology or catastrophic Spanish command and weather?

[8.1] *1588*

The Crescent Advances: Channel Skirmishes from Plymouth to the Isle of Wight

> ***"Why were English ships unable to break the Armada's crescent formation in open Channel water?"***

In May 1588, Philip II's **Spanish Armada**—130 ships, 2,430 cannons, and 30,000 men commanded by the Duke of Medina Sidonia—set sail from Lisbon. Philip's plan was to sail up the English Channel, rendezvous with the Duke of Parma's 27,000 veteran soldiers in Flanders, and ferry the invasion army across to Kent in flat-bottomed barges. However, the plan suffered fatal flaws: Medina Sidonia had no naval combat experience, supplies spoiled in unseasoned barrels, and Parma possessed no deep-water port, causing 48-hour communication delays.

On 29 July 1588, the Armada was sighted off Cornwall, sailing in an impenetrable, seven-mile **crescent formation** with armed galleons protecting unarmed transports. Over the next week, the English fleet under Lord Howard and Francis Drake engaged the Spanish in running skirmishes off **Plymouth** and the **Isle of Wight**. English captains used their faster ships and long-range **culverin cannons** in a gunnery duel beyond boarding range, denying Medina Sidonia safe anchorage in the deep Solent and forcing the Armada onward towards Calais.

[8.2] *1588*

Midnight at Calais Roads: Hell-Burners, Severed Anchors and Broken Formation

> ***"Why did the English use of fireships at Calais prove the decisive turning point of the campaign?"***

On 29 July 1588, the Armada was sighted off the Lizard in Cornwall. Medina Sidonia arranged his fleet into a formidable **crescent formation**, placing heavily armed galleons on the outer flanks to shield the slower transport supply hulks in the centre. This tactical wall was virtually impregnable to direct frontal attack.

For a week, Howard and Drake shadowed the Armada as it sailed past Plymouth, Portland Bill, and the Isle of Wight. The English used their superior speed and long-range culverins to bombard the Spanish formation from a distance. Although the English fired thousands of cannonballs, the sturdy Spanish oak hulls held firm, and only two Spanish ships were captured after accidental collisions. On 6 August, Medina Sidonia anchored in the open roads of **Calais**, anxiously awaiting word from Parma.

[8.3] *1588*

The Bloodbath at Gravelines: Hawkins' Race-Built Galleons and Close-Range Broadside

> ***"How did English ship design and gunnery tactics defeat Spanish warships at Gravelines?"***

Anchored in the vulnerable Calais roads, the Armada was exposed to disaster. Medina Sidonia discovered that Parma's troops were trapped by Dutch flyboats and would take at least six days to embark. Seeing their opportunity, the English commanders held a midnight council of war on Howard's flagship, the *Ark Royal*.

At midnight on 7 August, the English launched **eight old ships loaded with pitch, tar, and gunpowder**, setting them ablaze and sending them drifting on the tide directly toward the densely packed Spanish fleet. Terrified of "hellburners" (floating bombs), Spanish captains panicked, severed their anchor cables, and hoisted sails to flee. By dawn, the tight crescent formation was completely shattered, and the disorganized Spanish ships were scattered northward along the treacherous Flemish coast.

[8.4] *1588*

The Protestant Wind: The Ordeal of the Scottish Isles and Shipwrecks on Irish Rocks

> ***"Why did the combination of adverse weather and lost equipment destroy the retreating Armada?"***

On the morning of 8 August 1588, Howard and Drake struck the scattered Spanish ships in the ferocious **Battle of Gravelines**. Closing to within 100 yards, English race-built galleons unleashed devastating, rapid broadsides. Spanish crews, exhausted and short of properly sized shot, were unable to reload their heavy guns and suffered horrifying casualties.

Five Spanish galleons were sunk or run aground, and over 1,000 Spanish sailors were killed. Just as the surviving Spanish fleet seemed doomed to wreck on the Zeeland sandbanks, a sudden gale blew up from the south-west—hailed by the English as the **"Protestant Wind"**—driving the Armada away from the Flemish coast into the icy North Sea. With their ammunition exhausted, the English fleet turned back at the Firth of Forth, leaving the broken Armada to face the treacherous journey home.

[8.5] *1588–1589*

The Protestant Deliverance: Elizabeth at Tilbury, Medals of Gold and English Triumph

> ***"How did the defeat of the Armada transform Elizabeth's reputation at home and abroad?"***

Following the Armada's defeat, Elizabeth cemented her image as the victorious Protestant warrior queen. Riding among her troops at Tilbury, Elizabeth delivered her iconic address: "I know I have the body of a weak and feeble woman, but I have the heart and stomach of a king, and of a king of England too."

England celebrated the deliverance as a divine Protestant miracle, issuing commemorative medals inscribed: *God blew and they were scattered.* The triumph secured Elizabeth's throne, demonstrated the superiority of English naval tactics, and established England's rising Protestant naval superpower prestige on the world stage.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Naval Gunfire Revolution • Race-Built Maneuverability, Fireship Disruption, and Atlantic Tempests**

Hawkins' race-built galleons and fast-reloading culverins outmatched the cumbersome Spanish fleet, while hell-burners at Calais and lethal northern gales completed the Armada's destruction.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did educational expansion and popular theatrical culture transform English social and civic life?

[9.1] *1558–1588*

Humanism & The Hornbook: The Printing Press, Illiteracy and the Protestant Drive for Reading

> *"Why did Elizabethan attitudes towards social hierarchy limit educational opportunity?"*

In Elizabethan England, education was strictly governed by the **Great Chain of Being**, reflecting each child's predetermined social status. While the intellectual movement of **Humanism** encouraged education to train active citizens for public service, schooling remained an exclusive privilege rather than a universal right. Basic literacy began at home or in local **petty schools** and **dame schools**, where young children learned the alphabet, hornbook reading, and the catechism before boys entered grammar school.

The Protestant Reformation and the **printing press** accelerated national demand for literacy, as Protestant doctrine held that every Christian should read the English Bible. Although formal schooling was unavailable to the labouring poor, literacy rose steadily: by 1588, approximately **30 per cent of men** and **10 per cent of women** could read and write. For wealthy merchants and yeomen, securing a literate education for their sons became the essential gateway to commercial success and social advancement.

[9.2] *1558–1588*

The Latin Grammar School: Rote Chant, Birch Rods and the Making of the Tudor Elite

> *"How did grammar schools provide a route for sons of the gentry and merchants to rise in society?"*

The backbone of Elizabethan secondary education was the **Grammar School**. Over seventy new grammar schools were founded during Elizabeth's reign, financed by wealthy gentry and merchant benefactors. Grammar schools catered exclusively to boys from the gentry, yeomen, and merchant classes. The curriculum was gruelling: boys attended school six days a week from 6 am to 5 pm, studying Latin grammar, Greek, history, and classical literature, enforced through strict corporal punishment with the birch rod.

Younger children of the middling sort began their education at **Petty Schools** (often run in a local teacher's home) or **Dame Schools** (run by local women), where they learned basic reading, writing, and arithmetic using a hornbook. At the top of the system stood England's two ancient universities, **Oxford and Cambridge**, where young gentlemen studied law, medicine, philosophy, and theology, alongside the **Inns of Court** in London, which trained wealthy young men in statutory law.

[9.3] *1558–1588*

Oxford, Cambridge & The Inns of Court: Gentlemen Scholars, Lawyers and Private Tutors

> *"How did the education of the nobility differ from schooling provided to the middling classes?"*

Education in Elizabethan England was strictly divided by social station and gender. Wealthy aristocratic families did not send their sons to ordinary schools; noble boys were educated at home by private tutors, learning Latin, French, courtly manners, fencing, and horsemanship. Noble girls also received private tuition in modern languages, music, needlework, and household management, but were barred from grammar schools and universities.

For the vast majority of lower-class children—the sons and daughters of tenant farmers and agricultural labourers—formal education did not exist. Poor families needed their children working in fields or domestic service from the age of seven or eight to help the family survive. Working-class boys might enter a seven-year trade apprenticeship at fourteen, while girls learned housekeeping, spinning, and brewing from their mothers to prepare for marriage.

[9.4] *1558–1588*

Blood Sports and Tavern Dice: Football Brawls, Cockfighting and Aristocratic Hunting

> *"How did leisure pursuits reflect both deep social divisions and shared national culture?"*

Elizabethan leisure reflected the sharp divide in social hierarchy. Wealthy noblemen enjoyed sophisticated pursuits such as hunting on horseback, hawking, archery, tennis, and fencing. In contrast, ordinary working people gathered at village fairs, parish feasts, and alehouses to drink, dance around Maypoles, play early forms of bowls, or engage in violent parish football matches that often resulted in broken limbs.

Across all social classes, Elizabethans loved **blood sports**. Huge crowds flocked to purpose-built arenas on Bankside in Southwark to watch **bear-baiting** and **bull-baiting**, where chained animals were mauled by mastiffs, with spectators placing heavy bets. **Cock-fighting** was equally popular, enjoyed by monarchs and labourers alike. However, the growing Puritan movement fiercely condemned blood sports, fairs, and Maypoles, denouncing them as ungodly vices that defiled the Christian Sabbath and distracted people from prayer.

[9.5] *1558–1588*

The Elizabethan Playhouse: Commercial Theatres, Groundlings and Puritan Opposition

> *"Why did the theatre attract enormous popularity while provoking intense Puritan opposition?"*

The Elizabethan era saw the birth of commercial English drama. In 1576, actor James Burbage built **The Theatre** in Shoreditch, launching purpose-built venues like the Red Lion and the Rose outside the city walls of London to escape municipal bans.

The playhouses attracted up to 3,000 spectators across all social classes: common groundlings paid 1d to stand in the open pit, while wealthy gentry paid up to 6d for cushioned galleries. However, religious authorities fiercely resisted: Puritans condemned immorality and disease, warning that packed playhouses spread the bubonic plague, promoted blasphemy, and drew workers away from honest labour.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Cultural Democratisation • The Growth of Vernacular Literacy and Commercial Mass Entertainment**

The rapid rise of grammar schools and open-air commercial playhouses like The Globe created a common cultural language uniting nobility and groundlings across social divides.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did the Tudor state transition from brutal punishment of vagrants to institutional poor relief in the 1570s?

[10.1] *1558–1588*

The Hungry Generation: Population Explosion, Harvest Failures and Soaring Bread Prices

> *"How did the relationship between population growth and food supply generate severe poverty?"*

Throughout Elizabeth's reign, poverty and homelessness surged to crisis levels across England. The primary engine of poverty was rapid **population growth**: England's population jumped from approximately **3.0 million in 1551 to over 4.2 million by 1601**. This sudden demographic surge created severe competition for food, housing, and land, driving food prices sharply upwards while surplus labor kept agricultural wages stagnant.

The crisis was intensified by economic catastrophe. In bad harvest years (such as 1556, 1586, and the catastrophic crop failures of the 1590s), grain shortages caused food prices to skyrocket, forcing poor families to spend up to **80 per cent of their total income on bread alone**. Furthermore, previous Tudor monarchs had debased the currency by reducing the silver content of coins to pay for wars, creating widespread inflation that impoverished ordinary wage-earners.

[10.2] *1558–1588*

Enclosure and Rural Poverty: Sheep Farming, Rising Rents and Displaced Villagers

> *"Why did the expansion of sheep farming cause widespread rural unemployment and eviction?"*

Agrarian changes in the English countryside pushed thousands of rural families off the land. As the English cloth trade boomed, landowners realized that rearing sheep for wool was far more profitable than growing wheat. Landowners engaged in **enclosure**—combining small open agricultural strips into large, fenced pastures and enclosing ancient common land that ordinary villagers relied on to graze cattle and gather firewood.

Sheep farming required only a handful of shepherds compared to dozens of farmhands, causing massive rural unemployment. In addition, Henry VIII's **Dissolution of the Monasteries** in the 1530s had destroyed the centuries-old Catholic welfare safety net: monasteries had provided food, shelter, medical care, and alms to the destitute. With the monasteries gone, thousands of dispossessed peasants were forced onto the roads as homeless vagrants.

[10.3] *1558–1588*

The Fear of Vagrancy: 'Deserving Poor' vs 'Idle Beggars' and Social Anxieties

> *"Why did Elizabethan authorities draw such a sharp distinction between the 'deserving' and 'idle' poor?"*

Elizabethan society viewed vagrancy with genuine terror. Without a national police force, magistrates feared that roaming bands of homeless vagabonds would spread plague, commit burglaries, and spark violent popular rebellion. Sixteenth-century thinkers divided the impoverished into two distinct categories: the **"Deserving (Impotent) Poor"** and the **"Undeserving (Idle) Poor"**.

The **Deserving or Impotent Poor**—the elderly, sick, orphans, and disabled who were physically unable to work—were viewed with Christian sympathy and entitled to local charity. In contrast, the **Undeserving Poor**, branded as "idle sturdy beggars", were seen as lazy criminals who chose vagrancy over honest toil. Writers like Thomas Harman published sensational pamphlets warning of beggar tricks, such as "counterfeit cranks" who foamed at the mouth using soap to scam donations, hardening public attitudes against wandering vagabonds.

[10.4] *1558–1588*

Branded with the Red-Hot Iron: The 1572 Vagabonds Act and Compulsory Poor Rates

> *"How did the 1572 Act combine harsh criminal punishment with the first compulsory tax for relief?"*

As traditional voluntary charity failed to cope with the crisis, Parliament took decisive legislative action. The landmark **Vagabonds Act of 1572** introduced brutal deterrents: anyone over fourteen convicted of vagrancy was to be **whipped and burned through the gristle of the right ear** with a hot iron. A second offence brought life imprisonment, and a third offence carried the death penalty by hanging.

Crucially, the 1572 Act also recognized that the impotent poor needed organized support. It legally required local magistrates to establish a **compulsory Poor Rate tax** on all local property owners and appoint **Overseers of the Poor** to collect funds and provide weekly financial relief to the impotent poor. In 1576, Parliament passed the **Act for the Relief of the Poor**, ordering towns to provide raw materials (such as wool, hemp, and flax) so the able-bodied unemployed could work, while establishing **Houses of Correction (Bridewells)** to punish those who refused to work.

[10.5] *1558–1588*

Raw Wool and the House of Correction: The 1576 Act and the Foundations of Modern Welfare

> *"Why did the 1576 Act represent a major shift in the state's responsibility for unemployment?"*

In 1576, Parliament passed the landmark **Act for Relief of the Poor**, recognizing that the state had a direct responsibility to provide employment for the able-bodied poor. The 1576 statute ordered towns and parishes to maintain raw stocks of **wool, hemp, and flax** so the unemployed could be put to work producing cloth. Furthermore, the act established compulsory **Houses of Correction (Bridewells)**, where persistent idle vagrants were sentenced to hard labour and physical discipline.

The 1576 legislation established the structural principle that distinguish between poverty caused by economic hardship and idle vagabondage. When disastrous harvest failures in the 1590s caused famine and food riots, Parliament codified these measures into the famous **1601 Elizabethan Poor Law**. Under the 1601 statute, compulsory poor rates, overseers, almshouses for the impotent, and parish apprentice schemes remained the cornerstone of English social welfare until 1834.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Institutional Paternalism • Compulsory Parish Taxation and Statutory Differentiation of Poverty**

Driven by terrified perceptions of roaming vagabond armies, the Elizabethan state pioneered compulsory local taxation and distinguished between the impotent and idle poor.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did technological navigation and oceanic privateering establish England as an emerging global maritime power?

[11.1] *1558–1575*

Navigating the Ocean Sea: Astrolabes, Magnetic Compasses and Mercator's Projection

> ***"How did advances in navigational science make oceanic exploration feasible for English captains?"***

During the reign of Elizabeth I, navigational science unlocked oceanic exploration. English mariners adopted **astrolabes and quadrants to measure latitude** by calculating the precise angle of the sun and North Star, alongside magnetic compasses to maintain steady ocean bearings far out of sight of land.

The development of **Mercator projection global maps in 1569** allowed navigators to plot true straight compass bearings across spherical oceans without distorted courses. Equipped with printed navigational manuals and ephemeris tables, Elizabethan mariners gained the technical confidence to navigate boldly away from known coastlines into uncharted Atlantic and Pacific waters.

[11.2] *1558–1577*

The Race-Built Galleon: John Hawkins' Low Forecastles, Lateen Sails and Heavy Culvers

> ***"How did changes in galleon design and gun placement give English sailors an advantage at sea?"***

Revolutionary transformations in naval architecture led by Sir John Hawkins gave English mariners decisive advantages at sea. Hawkins pioneered the 'race-built' galleon, cutting away cumbersome high forecastles and sterncastles to create sleek, low-profile hulls with dramatically reduced wind resistance.

By combining traditional square sails with **triangular lateen sails**, English galleons achieved superior **manoeuvrable tacking in severe Atlantic weather**. Crucially, shipwrights mounted heavy **culverin cannons on compact four-wheel naval carriages**, enabling rapid broadside reloading by smaller gun crews to batter enemy vessels from safe standoff distance.

[11.3] *1550s–1570s*

The Quest for Cathay: The Muscovy Company, Guinea Gold and the Northwest Passage

> ***"Why did English merchants establish joint-stock companies to explore new global trade routes?"***

English exploration was propelled by commercial necessity following the **Antwerp cloth market collapse** in the 1550s. To break Spanish and Portuguese monopolies and diversify exports beyond European wool markets, London merchants established innovative chartered **joint-stock companies**—pooling private investment capital to share risks and profits in long-distance maritime trade.

The **Muscovy Company (1555)** secured exclusive rights to Russian furs and timber, while the **Levant Company (1581)** imported Ottoman silk and spices. Simultaneously, daring navigators like **Martin Frobisher and John Davis** led Arctic ice expeditions searching for a northern trade passage to China, expanding English geographic knowledge across the North Atlantic.

[11.4] *1577–1580*

Around the Globe: Drake's Golden Hind, the Straits of Magellan and Nova Albion

"Why did Drake's circumnavigation represent a direct challenge to the Spanish Empire?"

In December 1577, Francis Drake sailed from Plymouth aboard the *Pelican* on a covert expedition backed by Elizabeth to disrupt Spanish commerce in the Pacific. Surviving South Atlantic tempests and suppressing mutiny, Drake renamed his flagship the **Golden Hind** and navigated the frozen, treacherous **Straits of Magellan** in just sixteen days.

Emerging alone into the Pacific Ocean, Drake raided undefended Spanish treasure ports along the Chilean and Peruvian coastlines, capturing the bullion galleon *Cacafuego* laden with silver and gold. Sailing north to California to evade Spanish warships, Drake claimed the territory as **Nova Albion** for Queen Elizabeth, before crossing the Pacific to trade for precious cloves with the Sultan of Ternate.

[11.5] *1580–1588*

The Spoils of the Pacific: Stolen Silver, King Philip's Humiliation and Global Geopolitics

"How did the success of Drake's circumnavigation alter England's position on the world stage?"

In September 1580, after nearly three years at sea, the battered *Golden Hind* sailed into Plymouth harbour with fifty-nine surviving crewmen. Drake became the first Englishman—and the first commander in history—to bring his own ship through a complete circumnavigation of the globe. His captured treasure was valued at **£140,000**, delivering a staggering **4,700% financial profit** that paid off Elizabeth's entire foreign Crown debt.

In April 1581, Elizabeth knighted Drake aboard the *Golden Hind* at Deptford in open defiance of Philip II. Drake's voyage proved England could challenge Spanish maritime dominance, cemented English mariners as world-class ocean navigators, and inspired a generation of Elizabethan overseas explorers.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Cartographic Mastery • Joint-Stock Investment, Long-Range Navigation, and Global Trade Penetration**

Advances in magnetic instrumentation, race-built ship design, and chartered joint-stock ventures enabled English mariners to break Iberian trade monopolies across three oceans.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did Walter Raleigh's attempts to establish a permanent English colony on Roanoke Island end in complete disaster?

[12.1] *1584*

The Imperial Vision: Raleigh's Royal Patent, Arthur Barlowe's Expedition and Virginia

> ***"Why did Raleigh and the Elizabethan court believe an American colony was vital to England?"***

In 1584, Queen Elizabeth granted Sir Walter Raleigh a six-year royal charter authorizing him to discover, explore, and settle uncharted lands in North America. Raleigh named the territory **Virginia** in honor of Elizabeth, the "Virgin Queen".

Court intellectuals like Richard Hakluyt argued that colonizing Virginia was vital for England's future. Establishing an American colony would reduce trade dependence on rivals by supplying timber, sugar, and tobacco, while opening new markets for English woollen cloth. Strategically, Virginia would provide a secure naval base for Caribbean privateering, allowing English warships to raid Spanish treasure fleets.

[12.2] *1584–1585*

Mismatched Colonists: Soldiers, Alchemists, Grenville's Command and Lane's Fort

> ***"Why did the social composition and skills of the 1585 colonists create severe vulnerabilities?"***

In 1585, Sir Walter Raleigh organized England's first attempt to colonize North America, dispatching a fleet of five ships carrying 107 colonists to Roanoke Island in Virginia. However, the expedition's social composition created severe structural vulnerabilities: the party was composed almost entirely of soldiers and aristocratic gentlemen who considered manual labour beneath them, with virtually no skilled farmers to cultivate crops.

The colony suffered from divided leadership: commander Sir Richard Grenville clashed bitterly with governor Ralph Lane, who imposed harsh military discipline on the settlement. Accompanying the expedition were **Manteo and Wanchese**, two Algonquian Native translators who had visited London in 1584 to facilitate communication, trade, and diplomacy between English settlers and the local Secotan tribe.

[12.3] *1585–1586*

Shoals and Spoiled Corn: The Tiger Wreck, Food Shortages and Secotan Hostility

> ***"How did environmental accidents and food dependency undermine the first Roanoke settlement?"***

The Roanoke settlement was crippled from the outset by misfortune. In June 1585, the expedition's flagship **Tiger ran aground on a sandbar** off the Carolina Banks; seawater flooded the hold, ruining the colonists' grain seeds and perishable food provisions. Arriving too late in the season to plant crops, the colonists faced immediate starvation.

The colonists developed a disastrous reliance on local **Secotan fish weirs** and food handouts for survival. When European diseases decimated Native American villages and desperate settlers demanded unsustainable quantities of maize, relations between Governor Lane and Chief Wingina collapsed into bitter mutual suspicion and armed hostility.

[12.4] *1586*

The Severed Thread: The Death of Wingina, Drake's Rescue and the First Evacuation

> ***"Why did armed conflict with the Secotan force the complete abandonment of the 1585 colony?"***

Undeterred by the 1585 failure, Raleigh dispatched a second expedition to Roanoke in April 1587. Learning from past mistakes, Raleigh recruited **118 civilian settlers, including seventeen women and eleven children**, aiming to establish a permanent farming community. He appointed artist **John White** as governor. Shortly after landing, White's daughter gave birth to **Virginia Dare**—the first English child born in the Americas.

However, the new settlers inherited the hostile relations left behind by Lane's violence, and local tribes refused to trade. Desperate for reinforcements and essential agricultural supplies, Governor John White sailed back to England in August 1587, leaving his daughter, infant granddaughter, and the colonists on Roanoke Island.

[12.5] *1587–1590*

The Lost Colony: John White's Families, the Armada Embargo and the Mystery of CROATOAN

> ***"What crucial lessons did the failure of the Roanoke expeditions provide for future English colonies?"***

White's return to Virginia was blocked by the outbreak of open war with Spain. With the **Spanish Armada** threatening invasion in 1588, Queen Elizabeth impounded all English ocean-going vessels for national defence. It was not until August 1590—three full years later—that White was finally able to return to Roanoke Island.

White stepped ashore to find the settlement completely abandoned, the houses dismantled, and the settlement overgrown with weeds. There was no sign of a struggle, but carved into a palisade wooden post was the single word **"CROATOAN"**, the name of a nearby Native island. A sudden hurricane forced White's ship to leave before he could search the island, and the fate of the "Lost Colony" remains one of history's greatest unsolved mysteries. Despite its failure, the Roanoke ventures provided invaluable logistical, agricultural, and diplomatic lessons that enabled the permanent settlement of Jamestown in 1607.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Colonial Fragility • Mismatched Colonist Skills, Severe Logistical Interruption, and Indigenous Alienation**

Unprepared aristocratic settlers, loss of seed stores during the Tiger shipwreck, hostile relations with the Secotan, and the 1588 Armada embargo doomed the first English settlement in America.

MASTER KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL QUIZ • 1558–1588

60 CORE RETRIEVAL QUESTIONS

PARTNER QUIZ OR SOLO PRACTICE: Read each question aloud. State the exact historical fact, individual, or date. Cross-check paragraph references to verify your answers. Zero marks awarded for vague generalisations.

TOPIC CARD 1 pp. 4–7 • Ref [1.1]–[2.5]

Queen, Government & The 1559 Settlement

1. In what month and year did twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth I ascend the throne?
2. Approximately how much Crown debt did Elizabeth inherit from Mary I in 1558?
3. Which European financial exchange lent money to the English Crown at 14% interest?
4. Whom did Elizabeth appoint as her trusted Principal Secretary on her accession day?
5. How many senior advisors sat on Elizabeth's executive Privy Council?
6. Which English continental outpost in France was lost in January 1558?
7. What title did Elizabeth assume under the 1559 Act of Supremacy?
8. What fine was imposed under the 1559 Act of Uniformity for failing to attend Sunday church?
9. What liturgical book was made compulsory in all English parish churches in 1559?
10. What official visitations were launched in 1559 to enforce the Royal Injunctions?

TOPIC CARD 2 pp. 8–11 • Ref [3.1]–[4.5]

Religion Challenges, Recusancy & Mary Stuart

11. What term describes devout English Catholics who refused to attend Anglican church services?
12. How many London preachers were suspended by Archbishop Parker in the 1566 Vestments Crisis?
13. In which Spanish Netherlands town was an English Catholic seminary college established in 1568?
14. Which Spanish commander led 10,000 veteran troops (tercios) into the Netherlands in 1567?
15. In what month and year did Mary, Queen of Scots flee across the Solway Firth into England?
16. In which fortified castle in the Yorkshire Dales was Mary Stuart first held under custody?
17. What scandalous documents were presented at the 1568 York Inquiry accusing Mary of murder?
18. At which house outside Edinburgh was Lord Darnley murdered in February 1567?
19. Which Scottish Protestant earl led the rebel lords who forced Mary's abdication at Lochleven?
20. Why did Elizabeth refuse to pass a definitive guilty or innocent verdict at the Westminster Inquiry?

TOPIC CARD 3 pp. 12–13 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

Northern Rebellion, Plots & Mary's Execution

21. Which two Catholic Northern Earls led the November 1569 Northern Rebellion?
22. In which northern cathedral did the rebel Earls tear up English prayer books and celebrate Mass?
23. Approximately how many northern rebels were executed under martial law by royal order in 1570?
24. What papal bull was issued by Pope Pius V in February 1570 excommunicating Elizabeth?
25. Which Italian banker orchestrated an international Catholic conspiracy to invade England in 1571?
26. Which high-ranking English peer was executed on Tower Hill in June 1572 for his role in the Ridolfi Plot?
27. What 1584 pledge bound English subjects to execute anyone plotting against Elizabeth's life?
28. Which young Catholic conspirator used hidden beer-barrel ciphers to communicate with Mary Stuart in 1586?
29. Who served as Elizabeth's ruthless Spymaster that cracked the Babington ciphers?
30. In which Northamptonshire castle was Mary, Queen of Scots beheaded on 8 February 1587?

TOPIC CARD 4 pp. 14–17 • Ref [6.1]–[7.5]

Cold War with Spain, Privateering & War

31. What lucrative commercial licenses granted courtiers exclusive rights to trade specific goods?
32. What Spanish cargo ship carrying 26 tons of silver bullion was seized by Francis Drake in 1579?
33. What was the name of Drake's flagship in which he completed his 1577–1580 global circumnavigation?
34. At which royal dockyard did Queen Elizabeth knight Francis Drake aboard his ship in April 1581?
35. Approximately how much plunder did Drake return to the English treasury following his voyage?
36. What 1584 secret treaty allied Philip II of Spain with the French Catholic League against Protestants?
37. What August 1585 treaty committed Elizabeth to send 7,400 English troops to the Netherlands?
38. Which royal favourite was appointed commander-in-chief of English forces in the Low Countries?
39. In which Spanish harbour did Francis Drake launch his daring preemptive raid in April 1587?
40. How many Spanish warships and supply vessels did Drake destroy during the "singeing of the King's beard"?

TOPIC CARD 5 pp. 18–19 • Ref [8.1]–[8.5]

The Spanish Armada Campaign of 1588

41. Who was appointed Commander-in-Chief of the Spanish Armada following Santa Cruz's death?
42. How many ships and troops made up the Spanish Armada when it sailed from Lisbon in May 1588?
43. Which Spanish general commanded the 30,000 veteran invasion army stationed in the Netherlands?
44. On what date was the Spanish Armada first sighted off the Lizard and Plymouth?
45. What tactical defensive crescent formation did the Armada maintain while sailing up the Channel?
46. What naval weapon did the English deploy at midnight off Calais on 7 August to break the crescent?
47. Which decisive naval battle was fought on 8 August 1588 between English and Spanish fleets?
48. What name was given to the north-westerly gale that blew the retreating Armada into the North Sea?
49. Where did Queen Elizabeth deliver her famous speech declaring she had "the heart and stomach of a king"?
50. Approximately how many Spanish ships were destroyed or wrecked along the coasts of Scotland and Ireland?

TOPIC CARD 6 pp. 20–27 • Ref [9.1]–[12.5]

Society, Poverty, Exploration & Virginia

51. What wooden board with alphabet and Lord's Prayer protected by animal horn was used in petty schools?
52. Which prestigious legal institutions in London provided gentlemen with courtly and legal education?
53. Name the first purpose-built London playhouse, erected by James Burbage in Shoreditch in 1576.
54. What term described the open pit yard where poorer Elizabethan playgoers stood for a penny?
55. What agrarian process fenced off common arable land for sheep farming, dispossessing rural labourers?
56. Which 1572 statute introduced whipping, ear-boring, and compulsory parish poor rates for vagrants?
57. What 1576 statute established Houses of Correction (Bridewells) to put the able-bodied poor to work?
58. What technological navigational instrument allowed Elizabethan sailors to calculate latitude at sea?
59. Which courtier and explorer was granted a royal patent by Elizabeth in 1584 to colonise North America?
60. What mysterious single word was found carved into a wooden post at the abandoned Roanoke colony in 1590?